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Sex and the empire that is no more

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In this case, the rich scholarship distinguishing the social construct of "gender" from the biological construct of "sex" seems somewhat irrelevant. Westerners often justify particular actions or rationalize particular social arrangements by claiming that they are "natural," while they condemn other actions and arrangements as "unnatural." Talk of the "natural" is Americans' favorite "officializing" discourse (Bourdieu 1977). Hence, for Western feminists and other social critics, it has been important to demonstrate to the public that objectionable aspects of the status quo are not "natural," but rather are "constructed." Our officializing discourse, however, might do little to illuminate the dynamics of ideological hegemony and resistance in a West African society.

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It is not particularly revealing to observe that the Yoruba recognize that the "man" / "woman" dichotomy is "constructed" and is therefore not made compulsory by a sense of its "naturalness." "Naturalness" is not, in Oyo-Yoruba society, the attribute that makes any given behavior compulsory or preferred for a normal person. Yoruba people are little given to justifying their social conduct on the grounds of its biological or natural foundations. Therefore, Western feminist critiques of biological determinism are ill suited to revealing the concealed axes of power in Oyo-Yoruba society. The persuasive force behind the "husband" / "wife" metaphoric source is not that it "naturalizes" social hierarchies but that it socializes and civilizes nature in a paradigmatic way. It predicates cultural order upon natural disorder, a duty far more central to the Yoruba religious project than is, say, behaving "naturally." Nature, [204](#) or that category of things sharing the qualities of the "bush" (*igbó*), is not for the Oyo Yoruba the paradigm of social order; it is the origin of the inchoate forces (see Fernandez 1986) that must be contained,

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dressed up, and reconstituted in the Oyo-Yoruba politico-religious project. The sexually integrated nude bathing [L], the sexual joking at private cult parties, and the ribaldry at the beginning of public performances [M] [BB] are followed by a dressing-up that makes inchoate power socially usable. The containment, regulation, and social transformation of Sango's stormy, extrasocial force is predicated in the idiom of marriage. It is his wives who must contain and transform the wild.

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